



grief was once Russia, or Cuba, and, most recently, Iraq. Britain set sail on choppy waters looking for its grief and found it in the frigid Falkland Islands. India's grief is Pakistan, and Pakistan reciprocates this sentiment in turn. This is why Renan went on to say that thinking nationally was a wholly different enterprise from thinking rationally, and the two can hardly coexist.

When I go for my field trips to different parts of south India I often ask poor, half-lettered people there whether Punjab should secede, or Kashmir break away. Their response nearly always is, "No". Though these impoverished villagers may not know where these places are on the map, may not have even the vaguest idea about our Constitution, and yet, squatting in the shade of their mud huts, they don't want any more Partitions. Such is the profundity with which the formation of Pakistan has been seared into our national consciousness. The trauma of 1947 has consequently equipped us, as a nation, to trace imaginary lineaments of the State, even though we are frequently unable to draw the line between the "rational" and the "national".

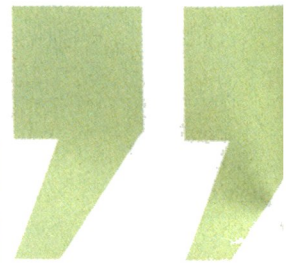
In spite of India's proven record of resilience, there is a constant stream of western academics that visit India only to find fault with our people. They argue that India does not have what it takes to be a sustainable nation-state for the masses are unaware of who the prime minister is, or the functions of the President, or the basic principles of the Constitution, and so on. I would like them to carry out similar investigations in the US or the UK for I wager they would also find people there too who are ignorant of the provisions of their respective Constitutions, and many would not

even know the names of their prime minister or President.

A famous American TV talk-show host once took his camera to the streets of Manhattan and asked New Yorkers about the significance of July 4, America's official day of Independence. He got the strangest answers. One said that on this day the ducks fly back home; another believed that this was the original Halloween day. One of them came close and got kind of warm when she said that on July 4 America had won a war. The TV host showed immediate interest. "Against whom?" he asked. The answer, very tentatively, was, "Against Canada?" On the strength of this can we then say that America is an inauthentic nation-state? After all, many Americans failed a simple general knowledge test in the most cosmopolitan city of their country.

It is better then to be more forgiving of frailties in other nation-states and more respectful of how each of them gets its flag to fly. There is no "best practice" as to how nation-statehood is achieved. But all successful nation-states end

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UNIFYING FORCE: Wars have sacralised our territory

